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We live in an age where there is an economy built on distraction and a complete corruption of attention. Tell me everything, the juice, the nuance, the details, and you got... 8 seconds. That's how long readers, viewers take to swipe to the Next Big Thing. Here is some trivia. We scroll 30 centimetres every 5 seconds. In a week, your thumb has scrolled 2.7 kilometres... pretty good workout!

I cannot imagine a more exciting but challenging time to be running a media organisation. We have two divergent mega trends, pulling in opposite directions—one, the empowerment by social media that has brought about a liberalisation of the freedom of expression. These new tools have given voice to large sections of society in India, which earlier went unheard, unintentionally. So, many alternative facts and truths are available, but the second mega trend is that we do have very highly shortened attention spans. You have a lot more nuance, but nobody wants to listen, so someone is always going to feel unheard and ignored. So, what is, and what should be, the role of a media organisation in a time like this? Is anyone with a camera and a Twitter and a YouTube account a media organisation? Is he a journalist? What is unbiased information these days? One person's terrorist is another's freedom fighter, one person's truth is another's lie. How do you distil?

What ethical standard or self-regulation are we talking about when passersby livestream an accident or give away a rape victim's name? What can you do about the fact that some media now prides itself in explaining the government's point of view with well-argued facts and graphics, and they do it without any pressure from the government? Are they independent? Are they media? Are they propaganda? Also, if you are always anti-government, are you independent? What's the role of media organisations in this new augmented, fragmented, filtered reality is a question I grapple with a lot. I think, as always, the truth lies somewhere in the middle. I believe the new role of responsible media is to build bridges, bridges across the right and the left. We do not subscribe to the tribalisation of news, the us versus them prism. This doesn't mean just being middle of the road; I believe we need to actively come up with innovative ways to pierce holes into partisan echo chambers, so they see a tiny bit of light from the other side to create a more diverse political listening. Because supporting one highly polarised truth may help social media algorithms, make for smoother news rooms and fatter bottom lines, but they don't help the social fabric of our country.

The new role of responsible media is to build bridges across the right and the left. To bring our audience from extremes to a place of constructive disagreement. Supporting one highly polarised truth may help social media algorithms, but not the country's social fabric

A Yale and Berkeley study concluded that even the most loyalist news audience can change their mind when exposed to different facts and perspectives. Our whole attempt is to bring our audience from extremes to a place of constructive disagreement. My whole team is built to argue till death do us part and, as the Executive Editor-in-Chief, I get the fun job of dealing with a newsroom full of strongly opinionated, argumentative, rebellious, questioning, hustling individuals...all characteristics of a good journalist. We are not afraid to ask questions. Our newsroom is built on dissent, an uneasy peace if you like, and I would not have it any other way. I think it makes us better—the more perspectives, the merrier— makes our stories more calibrated.

I see some disapproving heads. Calibrated? You are right. Every media in this country is right. Before you make your decision, do consider this. The media cannot play the role of the opposition; expecting it to do that leads to unfair charges of Godi or Modi media. If the Opposition is in disarray, the media cannot be blamed for it. We cannot present another side equally strongly if it doesn't exist. We are observers in this boxing match, we are not the players. If one side is weak or doesn't show up, we cannot jump into the ring. This is not fear, this is a matter of rules, roles, and competence. We are the medium, we are not the message.

Secondly, our role as media is to take you as close to the primary source of information as we can, not six degrees of separation but two. Straight from the ground or the newsmaker, with minimum loss in transition and translation, clean last mile of information and we always focus on that.

So, as we get into election mode and we see the great intoxication and toxification of news, do choose your news source, and your leader very wisely. ■